SPANISH AND LATIN-AMERICAN CONFLICTS

FROM THE 1840s to the 1890s the countries of Central and South America fought a number of wars that involved naval action. None of the naval conflicts was contested on a large scale, but some were of technical interest, providing a testing ground for the latest naval technology—as when the first sinking of a warship by a torpedo took place during the Chilean Civil War of 1891. The war that broke out between Spain and the United States in 1898, however, marked a major historical transition. The war was precipitated by the explosion of the battleship *Maine* in Havana Harbor—an event that was almost certainly an accident, but which was blamed by the Americans on the Spanish authorities, thus providing the former with a pretext for war. Two one-sided naval battles, at Santiago de Cuba and Manila Bay, to a large degree determined the war's outcome. As a result of the conflict the United States effectively replaced Spain as the imperial power in Cuba and the Philippines. At the same time, the naval battles confirmed the terminal decline of the Spanish navy and the emergence of the United States as a potentially major naval power.



Texan sailing ships
Sailing ships of the Texan navy head for the Yucatán Peninsula, where they engage and defeat the steam ships of Mexico at Campeche.

TEXAS-MEXICAN WARS

CAMPECHE



Date April 30 and May 16, 1843
Forces Texans, Yucatáns: 4 sailing ships; Mexicans: 2 ironclads, 4 sailing ships
Losses none

Location Bay of Campeche, Mexico

In 1843 Texas was a self-declared republic whose independence was not recognized by Mexico. The Texan navy was in poor shape, its crews unpaid and mutinous. Its commander, Commodore Edwin Ward Moore, sought to fund the navy by selling its services to Yucatán, also fighting for independence from Mexico. In April 1843 Moore sailed from New Orleans for the Yucatán port of Campeche, under blockade by the Mexican navy.

Mexico had recently bought the British-built, iron-hulled, paddle-wheel frigate *Guadalupe*, the largest iron ship in the world. *Guadalupe* was supported by the ironclad steamer *Moctezuma*. Commanded by Commodore Thomas Marin, the Mexican ironclads were mostly manned by British officers and crews. The Texans had only wooden sailing ships, including Moore's flagship, the sloop-of-war *Austin*, and the brig *Wharton*. Joined by two schooners of the Yucatán navy, Moore met the Mexican steamships off Campeche on April 30. The two-hour running battle was indecisive, but the Texans broke through the blockade and entered Campeche for rest and repairs.

Over the next two weeks the Texan sailing ships had long-range guns added to their armament, for they had had difficulty closing with the steam-driven ships. On May 16 Moore led his ships out of Campeche to renew battle. This time the fighting lasted three hours. *Austin* was badly damaged, but the Texan broadsides caused far heavier casualties. The Texans had the better of the two encounters, justifying the description of Campeche as the only battle in which sail defeated steam.

CHINCHA ISLANDS WAR

CALLAO



Date May 2, 1866
Forces Spanish: 14 warships; Peruvians: 5 warships, c.60 shore guns
Losses Spanish: none; Peruvians: unknown

Location
Callao, Peru

In the 1860s relations between Spain and its former colonies Peru and Chile deteriorated into open warfare after the Spanish seized Peru's guano-rich Chincha Islands. Admiral Casto Mendez Nuñez steamed from Spain on board the newly built ironclad *Numancia* to take command of a Spanish squadron off the coast of Chile. He bombarded the port of Valparaiso in February 1866, then moved north to Peru, choosing the fortified naval base at Callao as his target. The Spanish fleet had 245 guns on board, arranged in broadside. The Peruvian armament totaled around 90 guns, including some very heavy shore guns in armored emplacements. On the morning of May 2, the Spanish ships advanced within range and a ferocious gun duel began; it lasted six hours. The Spanish vessels received many hits, especially *Numancia*, deliberately positioned by Mendez Nuñez in the place of greatest danger. More than 40 Spanish officers and men were killed and a further 160 were wounded, including the admiral. But the Spanish had the better of the duel, silencing almost all the shore guns with their more skilful shooting. There were some 600 Peruvian casualties, including the minister of war Juan Galvez, killed in the destruction of an armored strongpoint. The Spanish squadron subsequently left for the Philippines, leaving the bombardment without consequence. Returning home to Spain, *Numancia* became the first ironclad to circumnavigate the globe.

WAR OF THE PACIFIC

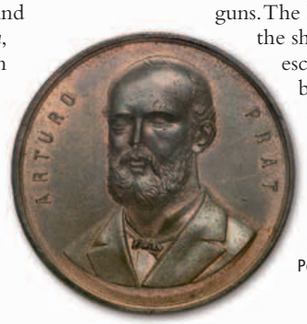
IQUIQUE



Date May 21, 1879
Forces Chilians: 1 corvette, 1 schooner; Peruvians: 1 armored frigate, 1 monitor
Losses Chilians: 1 corvette; Peruvians: 1 armored frigate

Location
Iquique, Peru

During the war between Chile and Peru in 1879, the Chilean navy left two obsolescent wooden steamships, the corvette *Esmeralda* and the schooner *Covadonga*, blockading the Peruvian port of Iquique. There they were surprised by two Peruvian ironclads, the armored frigate *Independencia* and the monitor *Huascar*. *Esmeralda* became trapped between the Peruvian shore batteries and *Huascar*, and although most of her crew were killed or wounded, her captain, Arturo Prat, refused to surrender. When *Huascar* rammed the corvette, Prat led his surviving crew in an attempt to board the monitor. He was killed on its deck with a blow from an ax. Meanwhile, *Covadonga* fought a skilful running battle with *Independencia*, exploiting its shallow draft to lure the Peruvian ship into going aground. *Covadonga* was then able to batter *Independencia* with her guns. The Peruvians scuttled the ship while *Covadonga* escaped southward. On balance, the battle was a victory for Chile.



Battle hero
This medal commemorates the death of Chilean captain Arturo Prat, who died boarding the Peruvian monitor *Huascar*.